A.SAVIN



INDIA PICTURE



MODERNIST HERITAGE (clockwise from left) the Thankaraj theatre in Kollengode, Kerala; a house in T. Nagar, Chennai; a building on Marine Drive in Mumbai; Metro Cinema in Kolkata; Hindu College in Delhi

imagination of architects in India in the 1930s and '40s.

On Mumbai's Marine Drive and along the Oval cricket ground, a cluster of 35 mostly residential Art Deco buildings were inscribed in UNESCO's World Heritage List in 2018. But the whole city boasts edifices that have been built in the same style. Atul Kumar, founder, Art Deco Mumbai, who is also on the Board of Directors of the International Coalition of Art Deco Societies, was the one who took the initiative to bring Mumbai Art Deco to UNESCO's notice. He equates the modern architecture of Deco with a deep sense of cosmopolitanism, and the emergence of the city.

The impact of Bombay Deco, as it's now often dubbed, also permeated the capital. Architect Geetanjali Sayal, founder, Deco In Delhi, recounts how she first did a walk through Ansari Road and Chandni Chowk on a Sunday, saw at least 10-15 buildings that couldn't be called pure Art Deco but which did have elements such as ornamental jaalis, balcony grills or typography. She realised there were some commonalities. "We realised some patterns bore a resemblance to certain buildings in Mumbai. We thought that this needs attention." She has since been working to document the many Deco buildings across Delhi.

Architect Ashmitha Athreya heads operations at Madras Inherited, an initiative passionate about heritage in Chennai. Apart from research, she also conducts heritage walks. "Awareness is growing. Participants are curious to learn more about the Art Deco style and end up relating a lot more to the Art Deco buildings they are surrounded by," she says. Athreya recommends visiting T. Nagar, Mandaveli, Gandhi Nagar, and George Town areas to spot Art Deco.

In Kolkata, Chelsea McGill, co-founder of Immersive Trails, says, "Awareness is growing, thanks to Instagram handles and walks like ours." Per McGill, Art Deco structures are scattered throughout the city and can often be seen right next to older colonial mansions. The most significant Art Deco clusters are in South Kolkata, especially in the area just north and west of Rabindra Sarovar, including Hindustan Park and the Lake Market area. "Unfortunately," she points out, "these structures are not protected and many are being torn down to build new apartment complexes." She describes Kolkata Art Deco as less of the classical kind you see in Mumbai or the US, and often featuring "a lot of Indian elements". Scholars have termed this form 'Indi-Deco', she adds.

In Mumbai too, a similar evolution took place within the Art Deco style, changing from a more Western interpretation at Oval in the 1930s, then on Marine Drive through the 1940s, and later in areas further north such as Shivaji Park, Dadar, an increased representation of Indian identities in the motifs and even the names. Kumar observes, "It was a shift from identifying with the British to becoming more comfortable with an Indian identity. For example, in Matunga, you can see Art Deco lettering in Devanagari and Gujarati scripts."

This distinct style of architecture and design can be spotted in almost every city across India, and many, such as those in Hyderabad, Jaipur, Pune, Kerala, Goa, etc., can increasingly be seen showcased on dedicated Instagram accounts. ■

Priya Pathiyan





IN ALL THEIR ENTIRETY (top) displays at the *Geoffrey Bawa: It Is Essential to Be There* exhibition, and (left) the Lunuganga project

The five or ten photographs and drawings on any given wall might share between them a terse caption or two, and the lighting, while dramatically subdued, often makes it difficult to see the fine details of the displays—one of which appeared to have rather unhelpfully been mounted upside down.

That being said, there's a lot to appreciate. Another of the displays is a huge, gloriously vivid photo of Lunuganga, a former rubber plantation that Bawa purchased in 1948 and spent the next several decades developing into an idyllic paradise. Delhi-based architect A.G.K. Menon says this is his favourite among Bawa's works, highlighting the essential wholeness of the developed estate: "The landscape, architecture, everything fits in. I have seen almost all his works in Sri Lanka—whether it is nature, climate, landscape, it is all reflected very profoundly in his work."

Even today, 20 years since his passing, Bawa's work remains tremendously influential, not just for its beauty but also its simplicity and holistic completeness. Architect Gautam Bhatia puts it this way: "Bawa's work is critical for our times because in every project there is a clear resolution of multiple ideas—natural materials, sustainability, climate-conscious design, green building, water and landscape...And he did it all without the self-conscious fuss we make about these things now." ■

Aditya Wig

(Geoffrey Bawa: It Is Essential to Be There *is on display at NGMA, Delhi, till May 7)*

PORTRAIT OF GEOFFREY BAWA, COPYRIGHT DOMINIC SANSONI, PHOTOGRAPHS COURTESY: GEOFFREY BAWA TRUST